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Raymond Firth

Life story interview with Paul Thompson

2000

Principle investigator's thematic highlights

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Sir Raymond Firth

Interviewed by Paul Thompson

7 January 2000

1. Early childhood: family and farming

(pp.4-5)
My father was from Lancashire. Townsend Fold, Rawtenstall… And his father, my grandfather, whom I never knew, was, I think, a small merchant, kept a china shop, at one time, and carpentry and so on. And my father emigrated to New Zealand with his father and my grandfather's three brothers. Two went off to Western Australia, and two remained in New Zealand.

My father, after a somewhat trying adolescence when his father died, and his mother … his step-mother, actually, had to be looked after … My father, .. [in his] late teens, had to look after them and earn the keep. But he did it as a boiler-maker, actually, and then as soon as his stepmother died, he left the boiler-making and went carpentering with his Uncle Henry, who was a builder. And from there, just rose up to become, himself, a builder, building mainly houses, but also some larger industrial buildings. He was, I think, one of the first builders in New Zealand to use reinforced concrete, that would be away back in 1910 or so... He died at the age of 104, in 1977.

(p.5)
My mother died… in 1962, at the age of 86…She was the daughter of someone from Northern Ireland. My grandfather, I still have his orange scarf, which tells you what he was! And my grandmother was the daughter of an English doctor. She had come around, I think, as companion to an English lady travelling, got as far as New Zealand and, in some way or other, met my grandfather and married him there. And they went, later, on to a farm, in the real pioneering days of New Zealand, where you "felled the bush" as we called it, that is the forest, and burnt it, and sowed and so on.

(pp.5-6)
We [my father and mother and I] were up on the farm, called "The Grange". It had been an old farm, I mean, well-established 40 years before, and then rather left to go into disorder. My father was, essentially, an organiser, a tidy-minded man, and he set about putting it into good order. For example, the 40-acre paddock, as we called it, when he got there, it was overgrown with gorse, enormous … blocks of gorse timber, almost young trees, shrubs.

And that had to be cut and burned and ploughed. And in ploughing, the four-horse team of plough-horses, would go and encounter a gorse root, and the ploughman would be tossed off his seat from the plough! It was a plough on which you sat, a disc-plough, he would be tossed off his seat with the four horses pulling this. And in the end, after some years, he got it into order. He'd hoped, I think, that I would be a farmer.

(p.6)
What he gave me was a kind of model of objective judgement, relatively neutral … To a kind of tolerance…. He was … not a very religious man. We were all a Methodist family, my mother an Anglican, had turned over, as it were, to Methodism, when she married. My father's name was Wesley, which is indicative enough! And we were Methodist. And in that sense, I think, we tried to follow the Methodist general prescription. But my father was not very religious.

(p.7)
My mother was much more emotional. A violinist when she was young, not professional, but with some skill I think. And she tended to hold what, in those days, were somewhat … alarming opinions. For example, war, the First World War, she detested, and spoke quite loudly about this. A loving woman, but quite a strong temper.

(p.8)
I was very much a farm boy, in the sense that I used to get up quite early. I had to bring in the horses.. We usually had about seven or eight horses there. And then after I'd fed the horses, breakfast and then off to school. As I said, on horseback. And in those days, there was a paddock attached to the school, in which one just turned the horse out with his nosebag of chaff and oats.

(pp.9-10)
I had a younger brother, seven years younger. There was a younger sister, who died at the age of two and a half, from some sort of pneumonia/chest trouble. And I remember my mother, it was a most bitter, bitter thing for her…

(pp.10-11)
PT: And how large was the farm?

365 acres….

PT: And so how many people were working on the farm?

Well, there were two men – Mr. Gilmore and Mr. Brady. They did the work of ploughing and harvesting, planting and harvesting, and all the rest of it.

PT: And would you get extra help at harvesting?

Yes. That was quite interesting. At harvest time, all the neighbours came. And my mother was cooking for them, and she would cook for 20 or so, a real solid meal. Not only that, they were given tea in the morning, and tea in the afternoon. And so we used to go out with buckets of tea, milk buckets full of tea, you see, 20-odd people. And they would come with their own horses and wagons. My father had also a couple of sledges, and we used to take part in the harvest too, the children, particularly the boys, and it was a real co-operative effort.

2. Religion

(p.22)
Well, the early stage of my life, I was a Methodist. And when we left the farm, and finally my parents came to settle at a place .. which is about ten miles out from Auckland, Ortara, in those days, was a sheep area. Now, it's the area for all the Polynesian immigrants, and has rather a bad reputation for violence and so on. But we had 30 acres of land there, we had a cow, which I used to milk, Jersey cow. And there, we saw quite a lot of church people. The church community was very important, indeed, to me. And I became Superintendent of the Sunday School in the end. And later on, my father also did a great deal for the church, and became Treasurer … He was a very practical-minded man…

PT: And did you make other friends who were important to you, through the Church?

Important at the time, yes. We used to go on picnics together, for example. In those days, you see, there were not many cars, so we went in wagons borrowed from the local farmers. There were two, two horses, or four horses, and we used to go on picnics to beaches … twenty of us, or something of that sort, you see. And that was really quite important. And, interestingly, Methodists, no alcohol. Never even thought of it…And another thing, we didn't dance. Dancing was not proper, really. I only learnt to dance when I went to the University.

PT: You did dance in Auckland?

I did dance in Auckland University, yes. No, bit by bit, it slipped!

PT: But anyway, at that point, before university, you were very much a believing, practising Christian?

I was a practising Christian. The question of belief is a rather more complex one.

3. Interest in the Maori

(pp.13-14)
My interest in the Maori… really developed from the age of 14, when I went into a bookshop, Whitcombe and Tombs Bookshop, and I saw Manning's *Old New Zealand*, and I was fascinated by it. Manning was an Irishman, who later became a judge of the Native Land Court. Married, I think, a Maori chief's daughter, and he writes in very amusing style. And I was captivated by it. And from then on, I remember, I began reading about the Maori. I read the *Journal of the Polynesian Society*, in the Auckland Public Library, at the age of 15 or so.

And from that, led on two things. One was to a more general interest in anthropology, because I moved from Maori to other ethnographic studies, and the other was to a closer acquaintance with Maori people, and so I got to know a number of Maori people. And also, I began to learn Maori, with James Rukutai, who was a court interpreter, a very nice man. And I spoke a very limited amount of Maori, but it remained with me for quite a long while. And then, also, I made various trips around the country, looking at the remnants of Maori buildings, Maori meeting houses, which are carved, wooden carved … Maori straw houses. I've written papers on these things, published papers…

As I grew up, from the age of 14 till the age of 20-odd, I spent quite a lot of free time … looking at Maori … When I was 22, thereabouts, I and two friends went on a week's trip, walking trip, .. going through Maori territory all the time, and we stayed, particularly, at a village,.. which I've photographed, and this appears in my book. And I've kept up one or two acquaintances with Maori people ever since.

4. Friends at School

(pp.20-21)
My great friend was Edgar Burton who became, later, a journalist on the *New Zealand Herald*. A very respected man. Slightly older than I. And I was almost a child of the Burton family for a while. I lived with them when I went to the Grammar School .. I think one of my greatest friends was Robert Faller, who became the Director of .. the National Museum of New Zealand, later. And he was, primarily, an ornithologist. And together, we

used to go out to the beaches of the West Coast. Now, those are iron sands, black iron sands, and they stretch for miles… But there, Faller used to go looking for birds washed up, because his great interest was sea birds, petrels, and he'd find the bodies of dead petrels and identify them, and gradually built himself up into a world authority on the subject of petrels particularly, with birds, New Zealand birds, in general. And I, on the other hand, was looking for Maori things.

5. University

(pp.24-25)
Economics I found really quite interesting. The professor … Grossman, a highly intellectual man, who had a somewhat chequered career, but he was quite a powerful influence, I think. This is typical New Zealand in the early days. He taught history, economics, and, I think, political science… And, in the end, came the examination. And the examiner for economics, was J.M. Keynes! I think, I don't know what the proportion of people that passed was, but it was very small. Most failed. I got 35 per cent. The pass mark was 33! The Council of the University decided that J. Maynard Keynes was a bit too tough for New Zealanders. By the way, all the papers, in those days, were sent over to England to be marked, so you didn't know your results for weeks and weeks afterwards. … So I decided that I'd do a Master's Degree in Economics. And in those days, the Master's Degree was by examination, but you could do a thesis…

So I thought, "Cowrie gum is an interesting subject", this was a fossil resin underground in the swamps… You probe for it, and then you dig for it. And the diggers formed a kind of reservoir of people for employment. When employment rose, they went to the towns and got jobs. And when the jobs stopped, they went back to the diggings. And they are a mixture of Yugoslavs, of whom there were quite a number, we called "Dalmatians" in those days … Yugoslavs, Maori and … ordinary European. So I thought, "Cowrie gum". And so I went to the books, and the material was mostly in the form of the annual statistical stuff and so on about production and sales and prices. Nothing about earnings of diggers. So I thought, "Well, the only way is to go and see them actually on the spot"…

That was my first, as it were, professional fieldwork, as distinct from the Maori, which was rather sort of recreational fieldwork. And so I went up, and I spent several weeks on the gum fields, talking to diggers about … their earnings, and all the conditions and so on, and discovered … royalties had to be paid to land owners. And then there were the people who sold the gum, and who, naturally, got more profit than the people who dug the gum… I published a paper on the royalty system in the cowrie gum industry, and also my thesis. So

I got my Master's Degree with First Class Honours.

And then I thought, "Economics is interesting, but there are other studies too". So … the next year, .. I did the Diploma in Social Sciences, at the same time as I was teaching at the Grammar School to earn my living. And the Diploma in Social Science included psychology, a certain amount of philosophy, I think. And that was taught by William Anderson, who was a very good man, a scholarly man. And I found that very helpful.

6. Arrival into the UK and LSE

(pp.28-29)
My father and I had some discussions, just as he saw that I would not make a farmer but would probably go into the academic field. So I think he realised that my heart was not in teaching, but in something like research, or the academic field.. He agreed he'd give me £250 a year for three years. And, in fact, that turned out to be a very good income…..The Commonwealth and Dominion Line had offered a number of free passages to students. I got one of these, and I set off on the *Port Hunter*, which was one of their vessels … a so-called "cargo liner", that is, they had about a dozen passengers, and the rest of it was all butter and meat and that kind of thing. And we went through the Panama Canal and, ultimately, arrived in London. I went to the LSE, registered there, and I intended, at that time, to still continue with economics….

It was still vacation, you see. So I said to the Registrar, "Well, my hobby is anthropology, and perhaps there is somebody I could talk to". She said, "Oh, yes, Professor Seligman. So I went up to Professor Seligman, and he said, "Can I introduce you to Dr.Malinowski?"

7. Malinowski and Postan

(p.31)
He was not so good as a lecturer. I mean, he was quite impressive in his way, but where he was really impressive was in the seminar. The seminar then, I think was a fairly new thing in British universities, and I seem to remember that "seminar" … from the German … meant "seed bed", and it was a seed bed of the mind. And Malinowski was superb as a seminar leader. The thing which always he would come back to is, "Now, what is the problem?" And you had to strip away all the accidentals, as it were, and focus on the problem. And he was continually analytical, questioning, and in that way it was most impressive.

(p.32)
Well, Malinowski, undoubtedly, was one of the really most powerful influences, intellectually, upon me at that time. I found, as time went on, that I differed from him in a number of intellectual respects, and emotional as well. But my memories of him are among the most vivid, I think, of my early anthropological life. Temperamentally, we were set in very different moulds. He was intellectually sparkling, emotionally outgoing, often mandatory, firm in statement, adroit in manipulation of persons, but fundamentally convinced, really, of the values of loyalty and friendship. He made a lot of this. Far-reaching in his imaginings too. But always with a certain touch of melancholy, linked with his frequent bouts of migraine and threats of illness...

In me, I think he found someone more sober, lacking the touches of brilliance which marked him, but contributing … adjudicating comments to our discussions. He said that on various occasions. More reserved in person, perhaps, less revealing, more tentative in generalisations, inhibited somewhat by what he called my "Methodist background", of which he made quite a bit! But he thought, I think, that I was reliable as a junior partner in intellectual achievements. And, undoubtedly, through his seminars I learnt a great deal for future teaching, and intellectual development.

(pp.34-35)
His theory of culture, as he worked it out, didn't appeal to me very strongly, this theory of basic needs. I rather left … parted company with him there... But the point about him was that we could differ like this, and you could go quite a long way in emotional build-up, and then suddenly, he would drop that and, as it were, lay on the table, in an extremely cool, analytical way, all the various elements, both of his and of mine, psychology. And that was very difficult to resist.….

About Malinowski, one of the things which marked him out in this country, among anthropologists, was his command of European literature, you see. I mean, his command of languages – French, German, Spanish, Italian, Polish, English – his recipe for learning a language was to get on a boat and take half a dozen novels in the language, and just proceed to read them! ...

I've always argued that Malinowski didn't invent fieldwork in social anthropology, of that participant observation kind, it had already been practised by people, certainly in New Zealand, and people like Edwin Smith… Missionaries quite commonly did this. Malinowski's contribution was his theoretical contribution, this perception of the general problem and the way to tackle it in a systematic way.

(p.37)
There was a great deal of camaraderie. Friendship was, then, I think a concept which was highly regarded, and without homosexual implications. There were, of course, underneath somewhere, some implications, but we were not aware of them, … or concerned with them, although we knew of their existence!

Among my friends, early friends, for instance … Michael Postan, the Professor of Economic History at Cambridge, we met at the LSE when I'd been there a fairly short time. We walked together a great deal in the Cotswolds. We climbed together in the Alps, and a little in Wales, very minor on my part, he was a much more … I think he was a member of the Alpine Club. … Rosemary and I occupied his house in Cambridge during the War, when he was doing other things. He was my, certainly, greatest friend in this country, and a very considerable influence on me too. A brilliant man, with, again, something like Malinowski, this breadth of Continental scholarship, which, in the earlier days, was, I think, unusual among British historians.

8. Rural England

(pp.39-40)
I was in touch with New Zealand House, the representatives over here, and they put me in touch with Lady Frances Ryder, she was the daughter of the Earl of Harrowby. She had worked with New Zealanders and Australians, and other Dominions people, in the First World War, and she had the idea that students coming over from these Commonwealth, it wasn't Commonwealth then, but Dominions countries, should be brought into touch with English social life. So she mobilised her friends in country houses. And I went down, the first Christmas of 1924…. They had a butler, a gamekeeper, preserved pheasants. They had a cricket week in which people came, stayed in the house, and played against the house and surroundings. They had shoots. … We dressed for dinner every night except Sunday, when the servants were off…

At Christmas, we had a grand time. Among other things, there was beef for the villagers. Sir Robert stood there, and the bailiff came with a joint of beef. The cottager came up, put down a cloth, Sir Robert took the beef, put it on the cloth, wrapped it, stuck a sprig of holly in, and said, "Merry Christmas"! And I don't know that they actually touched the forelock, but it was nearly there! And that went with a scuttle of coals to cook the beef.

Now, I had taken quite a number of photographs of "Brideshead" and various things, and I

was taking a photograph of this. Afterwards, Mrs. Williams said, "Raymond, that's not done!" And I felt properly rebuked! I'd never seen this paternalistic kind of thing, as might almost be in fiction.

9. The Maori Economy: contemporary and written sources

(pp.44-45)
I first thought, in the anthropological field, when I'd given up the idea of working for economics as such, ….of doing a study of Polynesian economics as a whole, which would have meant a great deal of comparative work on Hawaii and Tahiti and so on. I fairly soon gave that up, because I found there was an abundance of Maori material, with which I was already fairly familiar, and that could occupy me.

I didn't go to the original sources. … Letters, hand-written material of that kind, no. I didn't have access. And it is true that there is now available quite a lot of … material written by Maori and others in manuscript form. No. I worked simply from the printed documents, and to some extent, from my own knowledge of the Maori…. My own observations in the field, although very scattered, very fragmentary, were part of it. But mainly it just was the amount of literature on the Maori in New Zealand, and I worked at the British Museum Library – seat L5 – for something like three years!

It was three-quarters of a century in which people had been able to write. In fact, a century, really, when you go back to the very earliest materials.

10. The Maori economy: communication and change

(pp.46-47)
What I was interested in was the Maori, so far from showing a lot of independent actions and so on, were really all part of a huge system. And there's a chapter on communication, travel and so on, showing how they were in touch with one another. And the chapter on feasts showed them all contributing together. The examination of the gift also showed this … So it was essentially, I think, an examination of the evidence which showed how the system worked, because, in a way, people had previously taken for granted that the Maori, they fished, they shot, they snared birds, they dug sweet potatoes and so on, but the organisation of this was something that hadn't really attracted attention. I was concerned with what kind of organisation is it which allows these things to be done, which gathers people together. Who provides the plan, as it were, if such there be?

(p.50)
There is an idea that the anthropologists of my day were studying static societies, or, at any rate, societies which they imagined to be static. And this is quite false. We were, I think, most of us, interested in social change. And, in fact, in this Maori book, there's a whole section at the end about the changes that took place in the Maori economy, from the first coming of Europeans, with particular reference to land, of course.

11. Eileen Power, gender and feminism

(p.48)
Eileen was an admirable woman, charming … beautiful, in a way. One looked on her with admiration and respect. She was an intellectual, but an intellectual at a certain level, at a descriptive level, perhaps, rather than at a theoretical level. And I think that Postan had a very great influence on her by, as it were, representing to her the more theoretical level of what she was doing. I knew about their … attachment to each other, quite a considerable time before they married. In fact, I was a witness at their marriage, with her two sisters, Beryl and Rhoda. And I think that what Postan did was not only to supply her with a kind of … theoretical dynamism, as it were, but also, in a sense, of seeing her as a woman. She was, in some ways, in the earlier life, the three sisters were all rather Feminist, as they would say, particularly, I think, Rhoda, the youngest. But they all were … at any rate, Eileen was attractive to men, and, I think, relished this attraction, but didn't yield to it. She could have married several times, but didn't. And I think that this habit of treating men as objects of … admiration for her … was regarded by Postan as not appropriate. And I think, in effect, what he said to her was, "Look here, my girl, this won't do!" He treated her as a woman, and, in a most charming way, she was so.

(p.55)
In anthropology, certainly, we have always taken the view, I think, the people who I've been closely associated with, that it is the person, not the sex, that's important. And I think it's true that at the LSE, in anthropology, we appointed people on their merits, not by sex. But, you see, Audrey Richards, Lucy Meyer, Lorraine Burridge, Margaret Reid, these are all people of importance. There was no need for Feminism, in a sense, I think. It may be that a Feminist would take a different view.

12. Marriage

(p.101)
We met at the Gargoyle Club, which was a dance club, in which Eileen Power, William Postern, and Elizabeth Drew, were all members…I met her there. … She was just, just on the point of completion of her degree, which she got with first class honours, in economics, at Edinburgh. And I found her very attractive, and we … went on from there. And if you're talking of important influences, yes, that's one of the most important influences in my life. We've been married for over 60 years. And although, temperamentally, we're very different, and this sometimes comes out in vigorous arguments, even bitter arguments sometimes, fundamentally there's a very real affection. And she has had a most important influence as a stimulus and a critic.

13. On Freud and Marx

(p.53)
I've read quite a lot of Freud. And I think Freud is extremely important. One doesn't have to accept his theories, as such, but his methods, I think, are interesting. And, of course, he certainly was a great man. I mean, as I regard Karl Marx. Karl Marx is a bad politician, but a great sociologist, I think. Hence I call myself a Marxian, but not a Marxist! … No, not a Freudian really. But, no, certainly I regard Freud as very important.

14. Radcliffe-Brown

(p.99)
Radcliffe-Brown… a very interesting character. He started off as "A.R. Brown", and became "Radcliffe-Brown" later. He had been Director of Education in Tonga, and was, from there, appointed to be professor in Sydney. And he and Malinowski, together, I think were the two who really founded British social anthropology. Though very different in temperament, Radcliffe-Brown … very much the kind of … English gentleman, perhaps posing as an English gentleman, but quite widely-read, not, I think, in any language but French, other than English, but strongly influenced by Durkheim, and there was a time when social solidarity was his keyword, as it were. And his emphasis was on structure, whereas Malinowski's emphasis was on function. And so it was good, I think, for me to put both together, which, to some extent, I did.

15. Tikopia: Missionaries and District Commissioners

(pp.67-68)
The Melanesian Mission, their vessel the *Southern Cross*, called there occasionally, and they had made some converts. And about 1910, the Reverend Durrard was there for about a month or so. He couldn't do much anthropology because … as so often happened, some kind of … infection came with the ship. The Tikopia were very conscious of the fact that ships brought infection. Lots of people died, and so most of his time was filled up with listening to mourning chants and so on. It was a very sad time. But I got from him, a certain amount of information. I knew the Tikopia had no use for money, that it would have to be entirely a question of goods in return for anything they gave me. And so I had … some first hand knowledge of the Tikopia situation…

The Solomons, at that time, was administratively in extremely poor condition. There was a resident Commissioner, there were District Commissioners. District Commissioners were mostly people who had come out of the First World War, given appointments. They had very little qualification. As far as I know, only one out of the whole set of District Commissioners, spoke any vernacular language, they all used pidgin in talking with the people. Most of them hardly stirred from their residences in their districts. They certainly did very little for the people. They went into Tulaghi, which was the centre of government, every now and again. And by contrast, the Mission people, on the whole, they all spoke some Morta, which was a Melanesian language, which was the vernacular for the Mission. And some of them spoke the local vernaculars. And at least three of them had been really very important in the literature, in the anthropological literature of the time. Codgington, who died years before, did a classic book on the Melanesians. Ivans, whom I knew, had written a book. And in particular, Canon Fox, who was a saintly man, who lived among the people, and exchanged identity with one of the Melanesians, and who also wrote about the people. Now, by contrast, the Mission people knew far far more about the people of the Solomons than the administrative officers did.

16. To Tikopia

(p.57)
Having studied the Maori, I thought it would be interesting to see a Polynesian community at a much earlier phase of development. And so I had first thought of Rennell Island, which is a much larger island, in the Solomons, and I was making preliminary soundings about it. Tikopia was a second choice, because Durrard, the missionary, had done a little on its language. … I went to see him, actually, in New Zealand, and got from him some photographs and so on.

(p.58)
I gathered information about it from the Mission vessel, which used to call there about once a year, or every two years, and I discovered that it was obviously a very simple community, technologically, with very little, very isolated, very little contact with the outside world, and so I thought, "This is an opportunity to see what, really, Polynesian life was like", away from contact.

(pp.58-61)
I… set out for Tikopia from Sydney. I first of all took the *Matalum*, which is an ordinary passenger vessel, going once a month to the Solomons, and to Tulaghi, which was then the headquarters of the Solomons. And from there, I took the Mission vessel. And it carried me right the way round through the Solomons, the whole Eastern Solomons, on their regular tours which they did once or twice a year. Tikopia was very rarely visited. It's about five or six hundred miles from Tulagi. In the end, after quite some weeks, seven weeks, or something of the kind, we got to Tikopia…

It was very isolated. There was no government visit whatsoever. The Melanesian vessel, the *Southern Cross*, which was a steam yacht of about 400 tons, used to call there once every 12 months, once every two years, or, perhaps, even less. And that was that. So they put me down, with my stores, which I'd had to accumulate in large quantity. I mean, I'd bought jam, for instance, twelve dozen tins of jam! Crates of this, and crates of that, and biscuits and so on, tobacco, sticks of tobacco in large quantity. I knew that that, at least, would be welcome. Clay pipes, I received a hint that clay pipes would be welcome, and they were indeed. And steel tools…

My father had given me an adze, thinking it would come in useful if I were doing any building for a house, or anything of that kind. And this was an object of immense interest to the Tikopia, because they were canoe builders, in hard wood, and seeing this, I thought I'd better capitalise it. So I wrote to my father, and asked him for another half a dozen adzes. And the ship, the *Southern Cross*, came at the end of three months with further supplies, including these adzes. And then it didn't come for another nine months. It was supposed to come after seven months, but she broke her rudder … somewhere else, had to put back to Auckland for repairs, and so she was two months late. Nobody knew, of course, on Tikopia, what had happened. They said, "You don't need to worry. You're all right, you're on land. They may have gone to the bottom, but you're on land". Anyway, they did come, and so I was there just the twelve months.

PT: And you had no radio there?

No, certainly not! (LAUGHS)

PT: So you were completely out of touch for that time.

I was completely out of touch. I used to go out and sit under a tree and look out, and there was the horizon all around, you see, and that was that. Nothing broke the horizon for months on end.

I wasn't lonely... That is, there were always people around me, and I don't think that I missed the company of people like myself, because I was so absorbed in the Tikopia…. So, in a sense, it is true, I think, I was not lonely. On the other hand, what I came to realise was that I must be completely self-reliant. That if some kind of emergency occurred, there was nobody of my sort of general … background, to whom I could turn. The Tikopia would help if it were a physical emergency, but otherwise …

For instance, to begin with, I was trying to obtain information about their religious rites, and they, not unnaturally, were not keen that I should do this. And I remember, on one occasion, I was going to a ceremony around the lake, and before I set out on the path, I wondered, "Is it possible that they might club me?" because they used clubs. And I thought, "No. This is very unlikely". But I remember thinking then that this was a decision for me, there was nobody else to whom I can appeal. And I think that, in a way, this kind of feeling of, "I must rely upon myself alone", was one of the aspects of the study.

PT: And you were never worried about your health?

Yes. Quite definitely. I was … after a long period of religious ceremony, about a month, there was all kinds of late night dancing and so on, I was sitting out in the night, just with a shirt and trousers, in a deck-chair, and I got a chill. And I suppose I realise it now, it may have been a form of pneumonia. But I was certainly very ill for quite some time, two or three weeks. And the Tikopia, very cheerfully, said, "Well, friend, you're very ill. Don't die here. Go and die in your own land, because if you die here, the Europeans will think that we have killed you". So I promised them, to my best, I would not die there! And I didn't!

17. Adzes: altering the economy?

(p.63)
PT: You must have almost altered the economy, by bringing in those axes.

No, I didn't alter the economy because they had long given up their own clam shell blades which they used. There was hardly any available stone on Tikopia. In fact, I think the stone axes, adzes, that they had, were probably all imported, and only very few of them. But they made adze blades of clam shell, and used those for canoe construction. But these had been given up many decades before, because they'd had contact of vessels calling, for … water and … coconuts and so on, and even a few recruiters, away back in the mid-19th century had come. And so, in one way and another, they had access to some steel tools, but very, very limited in quantity. So the steel tools that I brought were very important to them. But they didn't change their economy, they merely amplified the resources they had.

18. First visit to Tikopia: moral issues

(pp.70-72)
I think it was a great influence on me, in a number of ways. I think I had to revise my views about the taking of human life. Infanticide was practised to some extent, and I could see the expediency of that. New-born infants having their faces turned down … against … a shortage in food supply. I had to think that one out a bit.

I was concerned with the whole problem of gifts and exchange, and … … services given to one. I started, I suppose, with the idealistic view that there could be … genuine help, without thought of return. And bit by bit, I came to see that this was a really absurd idea. Here were the Tikopia, I was a stranger in their midst, if they did something for me, it was not unreasonable to expect a return. Here was I with, from their point of view, huge quantities of steel tools and axes and knives, and fish hooks and so on, so why shouldn't they do their best to get these things from me? And so they did it with the greatest courtesy. I was continually invited to their houses. I was presented with mats and other things. And then they said, "Now, this is my *arufa*" – this is my affection for you, this token of … affection. "Now, you've got fish hooks", or "You have a knife I think I would like", or an axe.

This was a problem which bothered me for quite a while, because I could see that I was not getting information from them about the Tikopia, particularly the ritual side of things, which I wanted, and my goods were being drained away by these courtesy gifts, which I was expected to repay. And so for quite some time I had to work out that problem, and I finally evolved it in this way, that I let it be known that these things were, indeed, valuable, these axes and knives, and fish hooks, but I was keeping them for people who would give me information about the way in which the Tikopia conducted their affairs, including their religious affairs. I did not pay for information, in the sense that … if I was given a piece of

information, I paid for it. No. What I did was to let it be known that, in due course, I would make the gifts of affection, of *arufa*, to them. And the people who would get the best gifts were the people who informed me most.

Now, it so happened that the people who had the information that I wanted, mostly were chiefs and elders. So, naturally, the chiefs and elders got the adzes and the axes and the knives, rather more than other people. And that was quite in accord with Tikopia practice, that the men of seniority and status and rank would, in fact, get the best of what there was…

But I think that the greatest moral dilemma that I had was … against the opposition of these people, I was pressing for information about their most sacred things, and they were afraid. They were afraid that in giving this information, either I would use it against them, or the gods and ancestors, themselves, would be angry, and visit on them and their children sickness, death and so on. So, in a way, I was torn between pressing for information, which they were reluctant to give, and feeling that if I'm ever to understand the Tikopia society, I've got to press for this information and acquire it.

(p.75)
As time went on, they called me …."the chief who writes down what people say". And I think, after a time, they began to regard me, in the younger generations, as somebody who knew things which they did not, because I had gone through this earlier period. And in the course of time, first of all I was given different names. I was, first of all, the "*papa langi*" – the foreigner, the stranger.

Then I was … "*soa*" – friend…..But also, as time went on, I was given kinship terms. "*tina tusun*" – brother; "*ba*" to others – father; "……" – grandfather, as time went on, on the second and third occasions! But when I first went there, I was also, to the Chief, the *Ariki Kafaka*, in particular, I was "*tuma*" – son – and I was really taken into the body of the kinship system.

19. Vihella, Firth's servant, and mistresses

(pp 77-78)
His name was Vihella and the Tikopia called him "*vas salla*". He was a great success. He was lively, he spoke a dialect of Polynesian which was very intelligible to them. He soon picked up Tikopia. He moved a great deal among the bachelors and girls of the society. He ran my household admirably. That is, because, every day, almost, food would come in,

presents of food, and he would see to it that presents went out again and so on. He organised the whole food supply in and out. And I found him invaluable. He'd been sent to me by Mr. J.C. Barley, who was a District Commissioner, who was unique, really. He was the only District Commissioner I knew who spoke a vernacular language, and he'd actually married a Polynesian … I found that *Vihalla* was invaluable to me.

PT: So did you, through him, get more idea about the sexual activities of younger people?

Not really, because I had my own sources of information. You see, I did not take a Tikopia mistress, but as a bachelor, … I was assigned to, as it were, the group of bachelors and the unmarried girls. And as such, we could indulge in very free conversation, and did. So I learnt a great deal about the sex behaviour of the Tikopia, in evening discussions, laughing, songs and so on, gossip and the like, you see. And, in fact, it was one of the things which I think helped, as you might say, to broaden my mind! Coming from a Methodist background, one had been rather stiff about sexual matters. But I came to look on them with much greater freedom than before.

PT: Do you think it would have been dangerous to have taken a mistress in that situation?

RF: No, it would not have been dangerous, but it would have been inexpedient.

PT: Because?

RF: Because I would have had to have a relationship with a particular family, which would have put me at a disadvantage vis-à-vis other families. I mean, I would have been very much at their beck and call. So no, I ,,, I regard that as not… not on, from a scientific point of view.

20. Diary writing

(p.78)
Well, I tried to develop very systematic methods. First of all, my diary. A daily diary. And I divided it into sections – weather; myself; people; and very soon I added food. And that meant that, day by day, I could look back and see what sort of changes had been taking place. And as I've just given you a few examples, I recorded my own … frustrations and feelings, moral dilemmas and the like in this, not very fully. In those days, I think we didn't engage quite as much in the navel gazing as anthropologists are apt to do now!

21. Revisiting Tikopia

(p.69)
It's really a question of different objectives each time. The first time, 1928-29, I was studying, in essence, traditional Tikopia culture – the structure of the society, their kinship, their economy, their religion – and I was gathering everything that I could, including string figures, because at that time, the resources for field research were few, and I thought, probably, this was the last time that I would ever see Tikopia, you know, I'd finished that work. So the first was really a study of the traditional society, although I did take account of the history and I've incorporated that in publications.

The next time I went was in 1952, and then I had with me my colleague, James Spillius, who was invaluable in a number of ways. And then I was concerned with the changes that had taken place over the 20-odd years, partly external, due to contact with the outside world. The Tikopia, by this time, men were going abroad for work on plantations, and beginning to send back goods to Tikopia. They still were not using money to any extent. But it was, essentially, a study of social change, the second time.

The third time was 1966, where again, I had a companion, Torvin Mondberg, who is a great expert on Bellona, another of these Polynesian islands, who was very acceptable to the Tikopia, because he understood a great deal of Polynesian behaviour and thought … and language. And there, the emphasis was, essentially, on the changes that had taken place in their religious life. Because the first time I went, there was still … at least half the island was pagan, and I was able to make a study of their religious rituals, once I'd got their confidence. And I think it is practically the only study in Polynesia of a pagan religion, observed at first hand. As time went on, conversion to Christianity increased. There was still a pagan sector in 1952, and I was able to observe whatever rituals they performed. But by 1966, they had already all become Christian, for more than ten years. So I was able to chart the … the history, as it were, of Christianity. And I think that that has some interest, as a comparative study. One of my colleagues in the British Academy, for example, who was studying Anglo-Saxon conversion to Christianity, said that he'd been reading my account, and the thing that struck him was, a question he hadn't really asked before, "What about the people who did not convert, who resisted conversion? Why?" … So that was the third time. It was only a short time, only a month or so. 1952 was quite a few months, seven, or half a year.

(pp.76-78)
When we went the second time, 1952, it was to encounter a very great shortage of food,

due to a tropical cyclone, a hurricane, which later developed into a famine. And … of course, there are two views about famine that the economists have, one of which is the lack of food availability, and the other of which is that there may be food available, but it's not available to certain sections of people…..

In Tikopia, it was definitely shortage of food which developed into a famine, because the crops that they had planted were not able to come to fruition and so on. But, what was interesting was, that some people, of course, had better access to food than others. All the way through, there was a great theft of food, on all sides, people stole food from other people. But although morals degenerated, manners did not. And still, despite the shortage of food, Spillius and I had great difficulty in refusing invitations to meals, knowing that the food was extremely short there. And so we managed by sort of reciprocation and so on, to deal with that situation. But throughout, as far as I know, even children maintained the ordinary courtesies of a mealtime and so on, they didn't snatch food or anything of that kind. It was remarkable, the discipline, overtly. But underneath, theft was widespread.

(pp.85-86)
Spillius and I had a radio … generator, and he looked after that extremely well. And, in fact, it was very valuable, because through the radio, we were able to contact the seat of government. We were able to tell them of the state of food supply on the island, and to summon relief supplies. And the government sent relief supplies of rice and similar things, and asked us to arrange for the distribution, which we did. So we were able to be of distinct help to the Tikopia…..

PT: So you became a very powerful person in that situation?

RF: Yes. In one sense, yes. But I don't think we looked at it quite like that! I mean, the main thing was to get it out to the people.

PT: Did it not surprise you that it was you, rather than the chiefs who organised that food distribution?

RF: No, because the chiefs were not in communication with the government. Don't forget, at that period, no chief spoke English at all… It was all done, in a sense, in consultation with Tikopia leaders themselves. But they couldn't communicate directly with government…

22. Changing gender roles

(pp.87-88)
PT: I noticed you said that one change was that the young women were paddling canoes on their own. Was change in gender roles, one of your interests?

RF: Not … no. Not to any great extent. I would think that that would happen occasionally, but there was no overall change that women handled canoes. No. It just was that some women did handle a canoe.

PT: So why do you think there was a difference there?

RF: I think that, probably, a generation earlier, no woman would have handled a canoe at all. And I think there was just the beginning of change there, that women's roles … you see, in Tikopia, women have always had a very important role, but they were not priests at all, and they had rank, but not power. But I think that, as time went on, that has changed … as women get jobs of their own and that kind of thing.

One thing I should say, going back to the earlier visit, and that is how soon one got used to the idea of young women, and old women, too, being bare to the waist. I found, after a few days, I'd forgotten about it … bare-breasted women all around, just as bare-breasted men.

PT: So you didn't have a Gaugin type of experience, obviously!

RF: Oh, Gaugin's always been a favourite of mine.

23. Human Types

(p.110)
Well, it was, I think, a request, really. The title was not mine. The title was given me by Nelson. And it was intended as a comparative study to show, really, to ordinary readers, how people in other cultures could behave quite reasonably, although to us, their behaviour might seem odd. And at that time, I pointed out how Chinese women wore trousers, whereas in Europe, England, women wore only skirts. Of course, that soon went by the board as the War came! That in Europe, people shake hands, but in Polynesia, they so-called rub … touch noses, and so on, you see. And I think the whole intent of it was to give a reasoned examination of cross-cultural matters, as information to the general public. And it went into a number of editions. One of the important things in it, I think, was to try and destroy racist notions, as far as possible, and I gave quite a number of examples of that

type.

PT: So, in that sense, it's a book of its time. I suppose you were very aware of Hitler in the background, when you were writing it.

Rf: Yes. I think, naturally, the whole ambience of all professional anthropologists in this country, was definitely one of anti-Nazism, anti-racism. I think the threat of war was beginning to loom, too. I remember travelling in Germany, and seeing notices, "*Juden sind nicht erstattit*" – "Jews are not allowed", and this was on a bench in the park. This kind of thing, one felt, was absolutely abhorrent. But the threat of war was there, certainly, and any move to counter racism was regarded as the job of the anthropologist.

24. *Malay Fishermen* and their families

(pp.113-115, p.117)
Yes. Well, we got out to Singapore, oh, we went out on the *Perseus*, which was … had a fairly small number of passengers. It was a cargo vessel really, with passengers, a few passengers. We landed, finally, at Singapore, and through contacts with Rosemary's family, we stayed at the house of the Colonial Secretary, a beautiful old building. And then we went on up to Kelantan, which is the North-Easterly State, an unfederated State, that is, it had a British advisor, but was not directly controlled centrally. And there, we were able, ultimately, to get a house built for us in a village on the coast, and we stayed there for the better part of the year, studying the economy, primarily. But inevitably, also, a great deal of the social life as well.

PT: Perhaps you could describe that house?

It was built entirely of Malay materials, of course. It was a thatch roof, and plaited wall panels of bamboo, on piles, as they all were, to … among other things, avoid flooding in the winter, the monsoon. And a coconut tree palm growing through the roof. They'd built around the coconut palm, of course. Far too valuable to sacrifice to a mere house! And it had a veranda which looked out, a wonderful view over this beach and the sea….

With a kitchen at the back. And we had a Malay couple who acted as our servants. Mahmout and Jinbon. She was a very good cook. It turned out she had been a cook in a Rajah's household, produced magnificent food for us. Because, I remember, Rosemary thought might teach her to cook food in the European style. After a week, we gave up that idea completely, and we lived simply on Malay food for the greater part of the time, using a

small amount of imported tin food …

It was a study, primarily, of the economic aspects of their life. But I focused, particularly, on the production and marketing side, and Rosemary, after an initial period of getting to know the people, focused on the consumption/domestic side. And I think our books illustrate very well how a combination of husband and wife can contribute, I think, a great deal. Because my book on Malay fishermen, deals entirely with that particular production aspect – technical, economic and so on. Rosemary's book on housekeeping among Malay peasants, is a study of domestic management. And still, I think, there is very little that has matched it. It's not a subject which many women anthropologists seem to go in for. They produce a great deal of study on men's activities, but not, until recently, too much on women's activities.

PT: I think you say in your book how, for the Malays, it was rather appropriate that you worked as a couple with this particular role division.

Yes. This was the great difference from Tikopia, you see, as I soon discovered. In Tikopia, here I was alone, and I could get an enormous amount of material on the male side of things, a certain amount on the female side, but to a very limited extent. Whereas in Malaya, I could have got even less on the female side. In a Muslim community, one has to be extremely careful in one's inter-sex relationships. And Rosemary, of course, had access to the whole women's side of affairs. And this made an enormous difference to our understanding, because we could exchange views in the evening to check up, as it were, one on another, what the husband said, what the wife said, and so on…She was the wife, the wife of a fisherman, with whom Rosemary found a kind of affinity.

We had a wide range of informants, in that sense. I think that, probably, we would both distinguish between people who were informants, and people who were informants and friends. And I think that the manifestation of that is that we went back, I went back on three other occasions, but Rosemary with me twice. The last occasion in 1979, we were received with considerable pleasure, by the people we had known in 1939. So it was not a matter just of informants, but people who regarded us, I think, with considerable … affection is too strong a word, but considerable sympathy.

But, in addition to the fishing side of things, we did, also, a great deal more. We went a lot to entertainments of various kinds, and in particular, when we left, we gave, as a kind of entertainment to the village, partly in recompense for their hospitality and so on, a shadow play, which went on for three nights. And that demanded a great deal of negotiation as to how it would be done, and so on, because the shadow play is not merely a drama, it's a

ritual drama. … For instance, I noticed that the chief performer, on this occasion, did not wear a yellow waistcoat. Now, yellow is the sign of royalty … of high spirituality, and so on. And I asked him, and he explained then, that because this was just entertainment, it did not have any healing purpose or anything of that kind, therefore he couldn't wear the yellow waistcoat, he just wore his ordinary clothing….

PT: And that was a way of thanking people, then?

That was a way of thanking the village. They all attended, you see, and there were crowds, a hundred, perhaps 150 people crowded round every one of the three nights, to see this entertainment.

(p.119-121)
Perhaps I ought to say a few words about our Malay friends, apart from the peasant fishermen and so on. When we went to Kelantan, very soon we met what the British adviser calls "The Four Musketeers", that is, four aristocratic, in two cases, royal young men, who spoke excellent English, highly intelligent, and extremely friendly. They included one who later became State Secretary, one who was quite notable in Force 136 when the Japanese occupied Malaya. He … became Director of Education. And one who was the District Commissioner where we were – Nick Mustafa. A religious man, but a most kindly and helpful man. And we saw quite a lot of them. We were entertained by them. We did entertain Nick Mustafa, particularly.

I think the thing that struck us about Malaya in the earlier period, was the attitude of the Europeans. They viewed us with very considerable suspicion, that is, the majority of them. The civil servants, the MCS people, European, were of a rather different order. They all spoke Malay quite fluently, standard Malay. Some of them really knew a very great deal about Malay society…. Then there was another man, a planter, named Bangs, who had an estate right up river, and he employed Malay labour. Now, this was a time when Malays were regarded by most Europeans as being lazy, impulsive, as … not really able to perform effectively, and so on. And Bangs took the line that if you treated them properly, which he did, and allowed them to operate in their own way, that they could give very effective labour. And, of course, this was true. And one of the things, I think, that we tried to show, was that, given the circumstances, they were very capable of hard, intensive, effective labour. These fishermen work extremely hard….

But the Europeans, on the whole, that is the non-civil servants, were rather poor in their Malay speaking. They were rather arrogant and somewhat contemptuous of the ordinary Malays, and they thought that we were really wasting our time.

25. Returning to Malaysia: changes to the fishing industry

(p.124)
We went back in 1963, and there, I was interested, particularly, in the changes that had taken place in the fishing industry. By this time, there were motor boats, internal engines, there were nets, purse seine nets of quite a different type. There was ice for the preservation of fish, and the marketing system had altered because, since there was ice available, they could take the fish right away to market, to … to the central market ten miles away, instead of having it disposed of on the beach… In the finance, ultimately Chinese capital was involved in the provision of these engines and nets. And in other ways too, we saw the social changes taking place…

By 1979…. the role of the women had changed. I remember, some time before, that a group of Malay officers came to the School of Economics for training, and they brought their wives, which was unusual. And then, as time went on, a Kelantan woman was a radio announcer. And bit by bit they, I think, have come more into prominence.

26. Colonial Social Science Research Council

(pp.135-136)
Through Audrey Richards, I think, somebody had suggested me as a possible Secretary for the new Colonial Social Science Research Council. So in 1944, I was called to London, saw the Colonial Office people, and accepted that post.

My job was to try and get people out on to the field, as much as possible, on significant problems. So I accepted the post, and in 1945, I went to West Africa as one of the principal Colonial areas, so to speak, regions. I visited the four Colonies – Gambia, Sierre Leone, Gold Coast, as it was then, and Nigeria – travelling around. I spent, in all, about three months, finding out from officers and local people what kind of problems they were concerned with – agricultural, economic, social, and so on. And I published a report on that. And, as I say, from the anthropological point of view, regarded it as my job to try and get as many anthropologists into the field as possible.

27. Kinship in Britain and David Schneider

(p.166)
In 1947, ..we first turned our attention to this subject. I think a number of us in the Seminar on Kinship, had been talking about various societies, kinship, and people were talking about, "In our society", or "In British society", and I think, at some point, I asked, "How do we know that this is so in British society, in our society?" And nobody could answer really. And so in October of that year, 1947, a group agreed to go and ask some questions about the nature of kinship. And we took Bermondsey, which we called "Southborough", and the members of the group I think I mentioned in this little monograph that I published later on.

(pp.168-9)
David Schneider was a student, and later, teacher at the University of Chicago. In 1951, I think, we were looking for new lecturers in the LSE Department, and I invited two. One was Elizabeth Bott, who later went into psychoanalysis, and is a very distinguished figure there, in this country.

The other was David Schneider… A man of very strong convictions. I think that he tended to know the answers, even before he'd asked the questions. But a mind which played around in an original kind of thinking, with problems. You got, very often, the unexpected from David Schneider, which was well worth attention. Anyway, at Palo Alto, we talked about this, and set up this idea, and he was very generous, and he induced the National Science Foundation in the United States, to put up money for the British side of the project. It was conceived as a joint project, but operating separately, as it were, in its two parts. And then, oh, for several years, until 1965, really, I think, it was set up on this side with myself in ultimate charge. It was the investigation of a set of middle-class people, the kinship of middle-class people in this country, and considerable pains were taken to get a random sample to conform to the recognised sampling procedures, and we took an area of North London for that purpose.

(p.172)
So the book, when it came out, was by Jane Hubert, Anthony Forge, and myself. I, in fact, did most of the drafting of it, but the credit for it, certainly should be distributed in that way.

PT: So Jane Hubert, really, was in charge of the fieldwork?

Yes. Yes. Yes, she ran the field team.

(p.175)
But, you see, in the case of the Chicago material, David, I think, became impatient. After some time, he let Alice Rossi go. She was the equivalent of Jane Hubert on our side. She was a trained sociologist, I think, and very good, as far as we could see. But I think he became impatient, and took over the direction of the thing himself. An enormous amount of material was obtained, but as far as I know, it has never been published. One or two sections of it have. And David Schneider's own book on American kinship, is very largely David Schneider's own thinking about the subject of kinship. And he doesn't really use the Chicago material to any great extent. So that the asymmetry of the result has, from one point of view, hardly justified the initial programme.

(p.179-180)
I'm still convinced of the importance of kinship, despite all that's going on in modern society. And it will be interesting to know how far the traditional patterns are being eroded. They obviously are, but how, and to what extent they are being eroded, it's very difficult to know….

Well, on the one hand there is the whole question of jobs, and where jobs take you, in relation to contact with kin. That's one thing. Another is the extent to which alternative sources of support and entertainment are available, how far the peer group, for example, has tended to take the place of the family in influencing decisions and action. Another quite interesting thing to me, is the extent to which the coupling together of people, without reference to marriage, and the production of children by them, how far this is going to affect the situation as regards kinship – legally and socially – not legally.

28. Humanism

(p.191)
My last book, and it's called *A Humanist Interpretation*. And I think that I would call myself a Humanist. And I began, as you know, as a Methodist. Not a very ardent Methodist, but I think it was the moral and social aspect of it that particularly I was conscious of. And I actually had a position in Sunday School and the rest of it. But I found myself much concerned with matters … [such] as the significance of prayer, and wondering about it. And I think, as I said somewhere, by an intellectual route, I came out of Christianity into Humanism. I don't call myself an atheist, because God exists as a concept, a human concept. And, therefore, to say that "God does not exist", is not, to me,

meaningful. The concept of God exists. But as I see it, the evidence for God is essentially that which human beings produce themselves. If God should exist, according to the arguments presented, then what is to prevent the existence of the Tikopia gods, who are … the expressions of natural phenomena, on the whole. If God is omnipotent, omniscient and so on, the Tikopia gods are often malevolent, they punish, very severely, those who don't … I'm talking traditionally, of course, those who don't perform the proper rituals. But nobody can say, "They do not exist". It's a question of probabilities, and the probability is extremely low, that they do exist. So, also, I feel that the probability that the omniscient, omnipotent, all-loving God, is also a rather low probability, and I've given reasons for that. So that, that, I think, is my general position.

29. The role of theory

(pp.1-2)
I think it's quite clear I'm not a public figure. In fact, David Schneider, … … although he praised my fieldwork very highly, said, "No one will think of Raymond Firth as a major intellectual figure"….. David liked spectacular theories…. He's quite right in the sense that, if you haven't got ideas, you can do all the fieldwork you like, and it doesn't matter…. But the point is, you see, that the spectacular idea attracts attention, but isn't necessarily a contribution to the subject itself, in the end.